heretics.[60] Fournier's view was not a fringe notion. He went on to become Pope Benedict XII (1334–42).

Fournier's task as inquisitor, and later as pope, was to ensure that the Catholic Church's interpretation of the holy book would prevail. In this, Fournier and his fellow churchmen used not only violent coercion but also their control of book production. Prior to the advent of letterpress printing in Europe in the fifteenth century, making many copies of a book was a prohibitive enterprise for all but the most wealthy individuals and institutions. The Catholic Church used its power and wealth to disseminate copies of its favoured texts while prohibiting the production and spread of what it considered erroneous ones.

Of course, the church couldn't prevent the occasional freethinker from formulating heretical ideas. But because it controlled key nodes in the medieval information network – such as copying workshops, archives and libraries – it could prevent such a heretic from making and distributing a hundred copies of her book. To get an idea of the difficulties faced by a heretical author seeking to disseminate her views, consider that when Leofric was made bishop of Exeter in 1050, he found just five books in the cathedral's library. He immediately established a copying workshop in the cathedral, but in the twenty-two years before he died in 1072, his copyists produced only sixty-six additional volumes.[61] In the thirteenth century the library of Oxford University consisted of a few books kept in a chest under St Mary's Church. In 1424 the library of Cambridge University boasted a grand total of only 122 books.[62] An Oxford University decree from 1409 stipulated that 'all recent texts' studied at the university must be unanimously approved 'by a panel of twelve theologians appointed by the archbishop'.[63]

The church sought to lock society inside an echo chamber, allowing the spread only of those books that supported it, and people trusted the church because almost all the books supported it. Even illiterate laypersons who didn't read books were still awed by recitations of these precious texts or expositions on their content. That's how the belief in a supposedly infallible superhuman technology like the New Testament led to the rise of an extremely powerful but fallible human institution like the Catholic Church that crushed all opposing views as 'erroneous' while allowing no one to question its own views.